

From Alinsky to Zoom: Understanding Relational, Constituency-Based Organizing in 2021

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ABSTRACT

Research across political science, communications, sociology, and human-computer interaction has explored how modern social movements are leveraging technologies and digital tools to mobilize for social change. While mass mobilization has influenced policy, triggered revolutions, and influenced cultures globally, mobilization is just one method of collective action. In contrast, the more structured, relationship-focused practice of community organizing can also enable mass societal change, such as in the US Civil Rights movement and in the development of tech-giant labor unions. While there is exploration into how we might research and design tools informed by organizing, specific frameworks and practices of community organizing - such as the People, Power, Change framework - also must evolve in response to the ever changing landscape of technology in society. In this workshop, we will bring together community organizers, technologists, designers, and researchers to explore what it might mean to organize and center relationships in the modern era with (or without) computer support, in what contexts we should prioritize organizing rather than mobilizing, and how we might iterate upon our existing framework to respond to our findings. We will produce an iterated draft of a traditional organizing framework.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-centered computing → Computer supported cooperative work.

KEYWORDS

community organizing, mobilizing, relationship building, activism, computer-supported communication, social network

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1 INTRODUCTION

Research across political science, communications, sociology, and human-computer interaction has explored how modern social movements are leveraging technologies and digital tools to mobilize for social change [14, 16, 17, 20]. Platforms like Twitter and Facebook are increasingly leveraged for mass, rapid mobilization [2, 18, 19]. Extensive literature evaluates the effectiveness of these movements [20] and studies social participation in hybrid online-offline movements [14]. Jargon even emerges about eased participation and lack of commitment in such mass movements [17].

And while mass mobilization is influential, it is just one method of collective action. Another method, the relationship focused practice of community organizing, has enabled huge societal shifts including the Civil Rights movement, the election of Barack Obama, effective labor unions and beyond [8, 12]. This work is enabled not through spontaneous mobilization alone, but through the extensive on-the-ground relationship building and leadership development of a goal driven constituency. The differences between mobilizing and organizing are nuanced, and while many critique movements like the recent Amazon labor union campaign for prioritizing mobilizing over organizing, rarely do these critiques dive into the differences between the two, their relationship, and the specifics of each method of change making [13].

1.1 Organizing and CSCW

Researchers have long explored computer-supported relationship building and organizing work. Many within CSCW, CHI, DIS, and the Allied Media Conference have explored how design in community organizing can be grounded in the values of organizers, how current organizers practice their craft, and how different tools support this informal mechanism of civic participation [1, 3, 5, 9]. Asad and LeDantec studied the use of ICTs in “illegitimate” civic participation in Atlanta and invited fellow researchers in CSCW to explore supporting other informal means of civic participation [1]. The Allied Media Conference dedicates tracks to visionary organizing, and there is precedent and success in workshops within CSCW that enable academics and tech workers to learn to organize themselves [9].

However, while there is exploration into how we might research and design tools informed by organizing, specific frameworks and practices of organizing also must evolve in response to the ever changing landscape of technology in society. This kind of contextual responsiveness supports their pedagogical purpose of enabling further practice and participation in organizing, and we believe the CSCW community can contribute to that evolution. While there are extensive frameworks for and approaches to organizing, we

choose to focus on one in which we have particular expertise and that is practiced and taught widely.

1.2 People, Power, Change Framework

We, the organizers of this workshop, are trained in the People, Power, Change (hereafter referred to as "the framework") approach to organizing, as taught by Marshall Ganz [7]. This approach to organizing presents the initial framework from which we hope to develop new understandings of organizing and mobilizing that are more applicable in today's social context. This framework has its roots in constituency-based organizing, was formalized by Ganz in the early 2000s, and later became the backbone of "Camp Obama" [4]. Since then, thousands of students, researchers, and practitioners have driven change with this framework, and communities of practice like the Leading Change Network have grown to teach and support organizers globally in their practice [6, 8, 11]. In this workshop we hope to bring together community organizers, technologists, designers, and researchers to explore the following themes:

- **Computer-Supported Organizing:** What does it mean to and how do we organize and center relationships in the modern era with (or without) computer support?
- **Organizing v. Mobilizing:** In what contexts we should prioritize organizing rather than mobilizing? What does that mean for how we design across those different contexts?
- **Framework:** How we might iterate upon our existing framework to respond to what we learn from the above?

2 GOALS

To explore these questions, we will pursue three primary outcomes:

- **Community of Practice:** We will foster relationships developed across an interdisciplinary collective of technologists, organizers, researchers, designers who come together around the shared values of organizing and collective power-building.
- **Iterated Organizing Framework:** With that community and from the experiences they share, we will facilitate a first draft iteration of the existing organizing framework to emerge.
- **Generated ideation of new possibilities of computer-supported organizing:** Informed by that draft, we will develop visuals from the collection of participant drawings, scribing, and illustrations of the day that communicate the complex, emergent framework visually.

3 ACTIVITIES

3.1 Context

We will host 3 activities in a one day session in our workshop. To begin, we will work with the participants to understand the context in which we are working and coming together by asking the following questions: Who are we? What do we care about and why? What pulls us to organizing or mobilizing? How have we participated, practiced, or observed this in our own lives? Why are we drawn to this work? We will prepare and have two participants and facilitators model an example of a narrative engaging with these questions. We will then break out participants into small groups to

share basic versions of their narratives and build relationships, and then hold a discussion on these questions for the remainder of the session.

3.2 Approach

For our second activity, we will dive into the approach and practice of organizing versus mobilizing. We will engage in a series of case studies from participants who are community organizers or activists sharing from their personal experience, as well as a brief selection of case studies chosen by the workshop organizers such as the recent Amazon labor union vote [13]. After a presentation, we will split into discussion groups and dive into questions like the following: What kind of goals do each of these methods reach? When does mobilizing fit a need, and when does organizing? What are the relationships between these two methods? How does technology influence these practices?

3.3 Desired Future

Envisioning desired futures is a key practice of motivation in change making. In the spirit of work done by scholars and activists such as adrienne maree brown and Walidah Imarisha in their speculative fiction anthology, "Octavia's Brood," or Grace Lee Boggs in her concept of "visionary organizing," we will devote the final session of the workshop to challenging ourselves to envision new futures [10, 15]. Some questions we can ask in this session include: What would a future look like where we center relationships and a resilient, distributed, structure of leadership and power building for societal change? In the future unbounded by our technologies of today, how do we want to be supported? What is the dream of your change? Small groups will visualize potential futures through drawing and other techniques. We will capture the outputs throughout the session to deliver a co-created visual collection of envisioned futures.

4 LOGISTICS

All workshops will be facilitated using video-call platforms (Zoom) and their features such as breakout rooms. Further, we will leverage virtual white-boarding tools (Miro) to capture collaborative notes and ideas from the workshop. All breakout rooms will be facilitated by trained facilitators and coaches. In an effort to increase diverse participation, we will also use paper, markers, and other physical tools.

5 RECRUITMENT AND SUBMISSION PROMPTS

We will recruit participants through our social, professional, and organizing networks via email and social media. To further share this workshop, invitations will be shared through the Leading Change Network and their partners globally. We will invite participants to submit an overview of a project they have worked on in pursuit of change through collective action, design, or research. We will choose a diverse range of domains and will accept designers and technologists who articulate an initial understanding of or curiosity about what it means to design for mobilizing and relationship building.

6 ORGANIZERS

Margaret is a Ph.D. student in Media Arts and Sciences at the Massachusetts Institute of technology. She seeks to understand how social technology practitioners might leverage design and data in their practice, and explores methods to design technology informed by the values of these practices. She now trains and researches community organizing.

Emily is currently collaborating with Marshall Ganz at the Harvard Kennedy School to develop a research agenda around the practice and pedagogy of democratic leadership and organizing. She spent the last several years developing digital products and collective processes to support community-based organizations in evaluating their impact. She has a Ph.D. in Human Development from Tufts University and an Ed.M. in Technology, Innovation, and Education from Harvard University.

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